Singh and to use his influence to retrieve Peshawar for Afghanistan, so bringing peace to the region.

Lord Auckland was however quickly persuaded by Macnaghten to oppose any sort of pact with the Amir. ‘Nothing but the offence and jealousy of other powers would be the result of an ostensible alliance with Dost Mohammad,’ Auckland wrote in a memorandum soon after receiving the Amir’s letter.[76] He did not write back for several months, and then his reply was friendly but hardly encouraging. He said he was pleased that Dost Mohammad wanted good relations with the Company, but regretted he could not intervene in the dispute between him and Ranjit Singh, and hoped that the two would sort out their differences. He also said he wished for ‘Afghanistan to be a flourishing and united nation’ benefiting from ‘a more extended commerce’. He then concluded, in words that his actions would soon disprove, ‘My friend, you are aware that it is not the practice of the British government to interfere in the affairs of other independent nations, and indeed it does not immediately occur to me how the interference of my government could be exercised for your benefit.’[77]

The root of the impasse lay in departmental politics and jealousies. All Auckland’s information on Afghanistan came through Macnaghten and Wade, neither of whom had ever visited the country. The advice of Burnes, whose despatches from Kabul gave a more accurate assessment of the real balance of power in the country, could only reach the Governor General heavily filtered through the double distorting lens of Macnaghten’s summaries and Wade’s patronising commentaries, both of which tended to undermine all that Burnes was suggesting. Dost Mohammad’s ‘tenure of power has actually been very insecure’, wrote Wade witheringly in a covering letter appended to one of Burnes’s first despatches from Kabul in which he had praised the strength and stability of the Amir’s rule. ‘Popular commotions have occasionally broken out which he has found it difficult to suppress . . . My own sources of information lead me to believe that the authority of the Ameer is by no means popular with his subjects . . . The greater part of his Troops are disaffected & insubordinate and, though well equipped with arms, are generally very deficient in the qualities which constitute good soldiers.’[78]

In this way, Wade and Macnaghten kept assuring Lord Auckland that Burnes was simply wrong in his assessment of Dost Mohammad: the Amir, they insisted, was an unpopular and illegitimate usurper, with only the most